affected. After the Japanese occupation of Hong Kong in December, Britain became willing to support the plan to build a supply road to China—but it would have to go through northern Myanmar, not Tibet. That eventually became the Stilwell or Ledo Road, named after the American General Joseph Stilwell, who led the campaign, or Ledo, the small town in north eastern Assam, the starting point for the new military supply route to China through Myanmar.

Although no road was built from Sichuan to Walong, the pressure was on from China's allies to assist the Allies by allowing supplies to be sent through Tibet as well. The British sent Norbhu Döndup, the assistant political officer in Sikkim, to Lhasa to try to persuade the Tibetan government to help Britain and China in the war against Japan.

The Tibetans were caught in a dilemma. On the one hand, they wanted to maintain their friendship with India and Britain, and, on the other, siding with China in the war would set a dangerous precedent. In the end, the National Assembly in Lhasa stated that Tibetan territory could not be used to transport supplies to China. The kashag also informed the British that Tibet wanted to remain neutral in the war.[90]

However, the war and the arrival of the Americans on the scene meant that Tibet's international status, and its hitherto isolation from the rest of the world, was being challenged. Stilwell was the chief military adviser to Chiang Kai-shek, who was determined to bring Tibet under Chinese rule. In 1942, the canny Chiang ordered one of his commanders, a Muslim called Ma Bufang, to prepare for an invasion of Tibet. Chiang also threatened to use his air force to bomb Tibet, if they, as he said, 'worked with the Japanese'.[91]

There is no evidence to support Chiang's suspicions of some collusion between the Tibetans and the Japanese. It was not until 1943 that the Japanese spy Hisao Kimura set out for Tibet disguised as a Mongolian monk, using the name 'Dawa Sangpo'. He did not reach Lhasa until September 1945, by which time the war was over.[92]

In July 1942, Tibet finally agreed to allow non-military goods to be transported through Tibet to China. But the issue was so sensitive that the kashag asked one of its representatives to sign the agreement without asking the National Assembly for approval. The route that was used also bypassed Lhasa. Supplies were to be sent through Tibetan trading